

The Role of Alcohol in Ritual

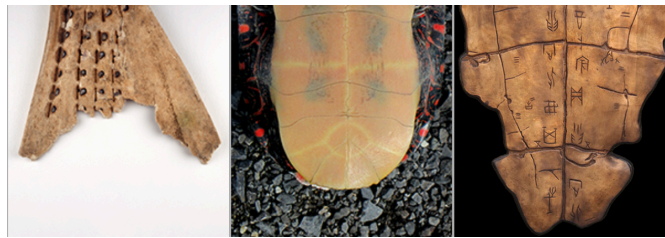
Alcohol has played a key role in ritual across human societies, past and present. One need look no further than the Eucharist, the ritual of communion in Catholic Christianity, in which wine (specifically, alcoholic wine) literally becomes the blood of Christ. During the Prohibition Era in the U.S.—when alcohol production, importation, sale, and possession were illegal between 1920 and 1933—wine was permitted to be produced for Catholic churches, due to its centrality to religious practice in the U.S.

Archaeological parallels include two related by Gremillion: Bronze Age Greece (pp. 106-107) and Iron Age Phrygia (pp. 107-108). In both cases, we find evidence of ritual feasting and drinking associated with the king. At Pylos, in Bronze Age Greece, the king provided the food and wine for the event. At Gordion, the capital of Phrygia, the feast was held as part of the funeral of a dead king, and likely only elite members of society participated in this ritual. Most importantly, in both cases, we have primary archaeological evidence of these rituals in the form of the discarded vessels in which the food and drink were served, as well as traces of the food scraps (bones and residues) and, in the case of Gordion, traces of the beverage, as well.

A Case Study from Neolithic and Bronze Age China

Alcohol played an important role in the Neolithic period (c. 7000–2000 BCE) and Bronze Age (c. 2000–250 BCE) in China. The article you read by Li Liu focuses on the role of alcohol in community formation in Neolithic China, which we discuss in the next section of this module, but alcohol was also used by elite members of society—especially the kings themselves—in ritual divination. We find this activity most visible (in both historical records and archaeological finds) in the Shang Dynasty culture of the Bronze Age, but it has antecedents in the Neolithic period. The practice centered on communication with the spirit world to predict the future—a form of divination known as scapulimancy, named after the scapula, or shoulder blade bone. The scapula, most often of a cow, or the plastron (flat lower-body shell portion of a tortoise or turtle), provided the large, flat, thin bone surface needed. This bone was incised, and a heated metal poker was pressed into a small divot in the bone; the directions of cracks were then interpreted as responses to questions about current and future actions, and used to plan activities by royalty. We find these bones archaeologically, sometimes in large numbers, such as at the famous site of Anyang, the Shang royal capital.





A burned, cracked bovine scapula with brief annotations (left); a turtle plastron (center); and a cracked, annotated plastron (right).

Source: Wikimedia Commons—[Scapula](#)

([https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Chinese_oracle_bone_\(16th-10th_C_BC\)_-_BL_Or_7694.jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Chinese_oracle_bone_(16th-10th_C_BC)_-_BL_Or_7694.jpg)), [Plastron](#)

(https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Midland_painted_turtle_plastron.jpg), [Annotated Plastron](#)

([https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:National_Museum_of_Chinese_Writing_\(10195726185\).jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:National_Museum_of_Chinese_Writing_(10195726185).jpg))

Most notably, these objects are the source of the earliest examples of written Chinese text. The simple pictographic system used on these objects is an earlier version of the Chinese language and a distant ancestor of today's modern script. Note how many characters that denote simple concepts began as ideograms—depictions of the items or concepts themselves—and later became more abstracted.

	Shang bone script	Zhou bronze script	Warring States script	Seal script	Clerical script (Han)
1. 'child'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	子
2. 'cloud'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	雲
3. 'water'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	水
4. 'year'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	年
5. 'silk'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	絲
6. 'be born'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	生
7. 'eye'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	目
8. 'fruit'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	果
9. 'tripod'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	鼎
10. 'deer'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	鹿
11. 'wise'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	聖
12. 'buy'	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	𠂔	買

Evolution of specific characters from earliest Shang oracle-bone inscriptions to “clerical script” of the Han dynasty (adopted c. 200 BCE), known in Chinese as lishu. This simplified writing system is the ancestor of all later Chinese writing systems.

Source: Table 41.1, p. 965, from Peyraube, A. (2008). Ancient Chinese. In R. Woodard (Ed.), *The ancient languages of Asia and the Americas* (pp. 136-162). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
doi:10.1017/CBO9780511486838.011

So, where did alcohol fit into this system? Many Shang-period bronze vessels, which were often well preserved in burial contexts and are now displayed in museums due to their aesthetic form and elaborate decoration, were designed for alcohol consumption. These vessels were used by elite members of society, including royalty who took part in divination rituals. Inscriptions on oracle bones and some of these vessels themselves indicate their use in the divination ritual: The diviners would heat and drink wine during these ceremonies as a way of communicating with ancestors and greater spirits.



Shang bronze vessels for alcohol storage (left, a zun); service (center, a jue); and drinking (right, a gu).

Source: Cleveland Museum of Art
(<https://www.clevelandart.org/art/1963.103>),
Cleveland Museum of Art
(<https://www.clevelandart.org/art/1960.42>), The Met Museum
(<https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/44774?sortBy=Relevance&ft=shang&offset=0&rpp=40&pos=15>).

Earlier versions of these exact vessels from the Neolithic period appear in clay, so we know that aspects of this ritualized consumption of alcohol took place in the earlier Neolithic, as well.